Field-cooperative neural topic modeling of civil engineering literature: missing-abstract inference

Abstract

Engineering libraries and design offices hold far more bibliographic records than any team can read in full, and many of these records are catalogued with a title but no abstract. We consider a practical form of this problem: organising civil engineering title–abstract records into interpretable topics, and still assigning topics when the abstract is missing. **Contribution to artificial intelligence:** we present FC-NTM, a field-cooperative neural topic model in which each field of a record is encoded by its own conditional variational stream while one linear topic decoder is shared across the streams; cross-field reconstruction, a consistency term, field-level word masking and whole-field dropout allow a single trained model to serve complete records, partially observed records and title-only records, and a unified topic–word read-out protocol under one evaluation vocabulary separates read-out effects from model effects in comparative evaluation. **Engineering application:** the model is evaluated on 8,000 civil engineering title–abstract records from OpenAlex. FC-NTM attains the highest topic coherence of the ten methods evaluated. In a ten-seed paired comparison against the biterm topic model it is ahead in every seed, with coherence gains of +0.049 for the class term-frequency–inverse-document-frequency read-out and +0.061 for the β read-out. Title-only routing reaches an accuracy of 0.664 against automatically assigned OpenAlex subject labels on the covered subset, supporting browsing and screening of engineering records. Occlusion experiments quantify inference stability under missing-field conditions on the civil corpus, GitHub issues and AG News, and identify the corpus conditions under which field cooperation produces consistent gains.

Keywords: Neural topic model, field cooperation, neural variational inference, missing data, civil engineering literature, text mining

1 Introduction

Paper and report collections in engineering libraries and design offices grow faster than anyone can read them, and in many catalogues the abstract is simply absent — the title is all that circulates. If the records could still be sorted into interpretable topics with titles alone, staff could browse and screen a collection cheaply, leaving the fine cataloguing to experts. Title–abstract records are one instance of a pattern that recurs across engineering documents: a short summary-like field sits next to a longer

contextual field, as in a clause and the contract around it, or a report headline and its body. And the two fields rarely say the same thing in the same way. Bodies carry context and causes; summaries carry objects and actions.

Topic models reduce an unlabelled collection to a set of interpretable topic structures, and domain-specific text mining relies on them in settings as varied as financial news García-Méndez et al. (2023), software repositories and social media. Latent topics have also been coupled with downstream neural encoders for large-scale text classification Qin et al. (2024). The model families themselves have shifted over the past decade, from probabilistic graphical models to neural variational ones. LDA Blei et al. (2003) is the classical bag-of-words Bayesian model. GSDMM targets short texts with a collapsed Gibbs Dirichlet–multinomial mixture Yin and Wang (2014). With AVITM, autoencoding variational inference entered the field and produced ProdLDA, whose linear topic–word decoder is easy to read Srivastava and Sutton (2017). NVDM applied variational auto-encoders to text early on Miao et al. (2016); CTM and CombinedTM added contextual sentence embeddings to bag-of-words counts Bianchi et al. (2021); ETM placed topics in a word-embedding space Dieng et al. (2020). BTM, the biterm topic model, keeps representing each text through word pairs and remains a strong baseline for short texts Yan et al. (2013). Surveys treat structured and short-text corpora as open problems for neural topic models Wu et al. (2024).

When the fields are concatenated into a single bag of words, as most neural topic models do implicitly, the internal field structure of a document is lost. A separate literature comes closer: multi-view and multi-source learning across heterogeneous observations Kurle et al. (2019); Zhang et al. (2017); Pergola et al. (2021); Liu et al. (2022), structured topic models for reviews that encode user–item context and sentence-level aspects Esmaeili et al. (2019), and structural topic models with document-level covariates Roberts et al. (2019). On the short-text side, DV-BTM optimises two views jointly Liu et al. (2022), CRNTM reinforces topic inference with context Feng et al. (2022), and DVI-DTM learns dual-view representations for dynamic topics Liu et al. (2026). In all of these the views carry known, externally given roles — source-specific observations Kurle et al. (2019), opinions and plots in reviews Pergola et al. (2021), aspects in review models Esmaeili et al. (2019). Here the roles are not given. The two fields of the *same* record are modelled by separate variational streams, and their relation comes from the record schema rather than from an extra latent variable. Separate encoders, posterior alignment and missing-view inference are all established; what this study adds is the field-cooperative configuration itself, together with the read-out protocol that measures what each field contributes.

Engineering informatics, meanwhile, has built up a text-mining practice of its own: safety reports content-analysed and classified Tixier et al. (2016); Zhang et al. (2019), regulations and contracts processed automatically down to contractual risk clauses Salama and El-Gohary (2016); Zhou and El-Gohary (2016); Moon et al. (2022); Pham and Han (2023), and dedicated surveys of natural language processing for construction Wu et al. (2022); Shamshiri et al. (2024). Topic models have joined in — DUET for physical events in urban social media Wang and Taylor (2019), a mapping of machine-learning applications in buildings Zhou et al. (2025), taxonomies for digital building passports Vangelova et al. (2026). What none of these applications do is

open the record and look inside. That is the step taken here: topic inference when a field is missing, field-restricted read-out, and a check of whether such read-outs can be measured reliably.

We make three contributions.

1. **A field-cooperative neural topic model with native missing-field support.** FC-NTM encodes the two fields of a record in separate conditional variational streams that share one linear topic decoder. Cross-field reconstruction and a field-consistency regulariser tie the two fields into a shared topic space, and field-level word masking with whole-field dropout lets a single trained model serve complete, partially observed and title-only records without retraining or architectural change.
2. **A unified topic–word read-out protocol for comparative evaluation.** All models are scored on one evaluation vocabulary with exactly ten words per topic, each model being read out both through its native topic–word matrix and through a class term-frequency–inverse-document-frequency (TF–IDF) read-out. This separates differences caused by the read-out from differences caused by the model — a common confound in topic-model benchmarking — and is what makes the reported comparisons interpretable.
3. **Multi-seed evidence on when field cooperation helps, and an engineering screening task.** Ten-seed paired comparisons show reproducible gains on the civil engineering corpus (+0.049 for the class TF–IDF read-out and +0.061 for the β read-out; 10/10 seeds) and on GitHub issues (+0.028; 9/10 seeds), but not on AG News (−0.009; 3/10 seeds). A same-budget concatenated-field control attributes little of the mean-coherence gain to the two-stream structure: relative to the classical and neural baselines, most of the gain is already obtained by a single encoder that shares the same decoder and budget, and the two-stream structure adds +0.010–+0.029 on top, while field-level posteriors and native missing-field inference remain exclusive to the complete configuration. A title-only routing experiment on the civil corpus (0.664 accuracy on the evaluated subset) shows how the trained model can screen engineering records from titles alone.

Figure 1 summarises the problem setting and the three contributions: dual-field scholarly records whose abstracts may be missing, the field-cooperative configuration that trains both fields against one shared decoder, and the observation regimes a single trained model has to serve.

2 Related work

Neural topic models.

Neural topic models map a bag of words to a latent Gaussian posterior and decode topics from it. NVDM was the early application of variational auto-encoders to text Miao et al. (2016); AVITM brought autoencoding variational inference and, through its ProdLDA variant, a linear decoder whose topic–word matrix can be read directly Srivastava and Sutton (2017). CTM and CombinedTM concatenate sentence embeddings with bag-of-words counts Bianchi et al. (2021), ETM places topics in an embedding space Dieng et al. (2020), and for short texts BTM keeps to word pairs Yan et al.

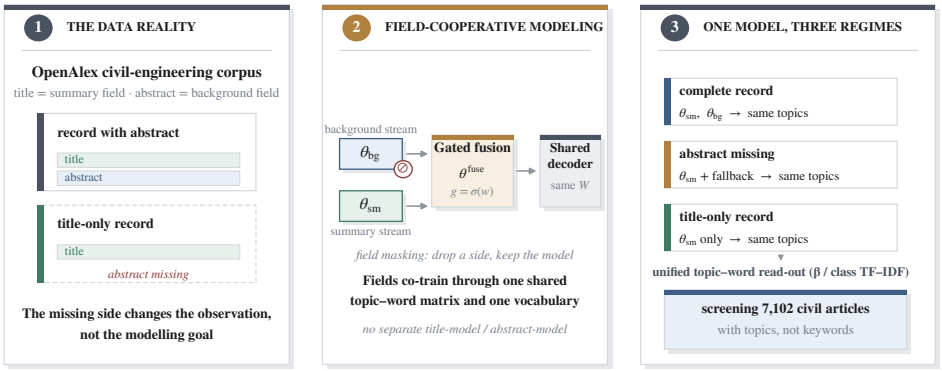


Fig. 1 Problem setting and contributions. (1) The application corpus is dual-field scholarly metadata in which the abstract (background field) may be missing, leaving title-only records. (2) FC-NTM encodes both fields with separate conditional variational streams tied to one shared topic–word decoder; field masking drops a side at training or inference time without changing the model. (3) One trained model serves complete, abstract-missing and title-only records through a unified topic–word read-out, supporting topic-based screening of civil-engineering literature.

(2013). BERTopic builds its topic representations from class TF–IDF Grootendorst (2022); Top2Vec learns joint document, word and topic embeddings Angelov (2020). GraphBTM and BCK-TM add word-pair structure Zhu et al. (2018); Zhang et al. (2022), and BigARTM contributes an additive regularisation framework Vorontsov et al. (2015). Topic-distribution quantisation with a negative-sampling decoder is a more recent short-text option Wu et al. (2020). Our own decoder follows ProdLDA, with topic orthogonality, dropout Srivastava et al. (2014) and validation-based early stopping Prechelt (1998); beyond that, objectives, training loops and learning rates differ across the algorithms.

Multi-view, multimodal and structured-document models.

Sharing information across views is a central concern of multi-view latent-variable learning: multi-source variational inference Kurle et al. (2019), robust multi-view topic modelling Zhang et al. (2017), and the disentangled or dual-view topic models Pergola et al. (2021); Liu et al. (2022). Structured neural topic models for reviews Esmaeili et al. (2019) and metadata-conditioned models Card et al. (2018); Roberts et al. (2019) exploit other kinds of document structure. CRNTM and DVI-DTM are recent short-text examples Feng et al. (2022); Liu et al. (2026), with related word-pair models nearby Li et al. (2019); Zhu et al. (2021). Kurle et al. encode each source separately and align the posterior representations, JMVAE-kl infers a missing modality from those that remain Suzuki et al. (2016), and SubNTM models sub-document topics Nguyen et al. (2026). What fixes our setting is the record schema: two textual fields, one shared vocabulary, one linear decoder — and a question none of the above asks, namely what field-restricted read-outs and missing-background inference actually measure. The established components are applied at the field level.

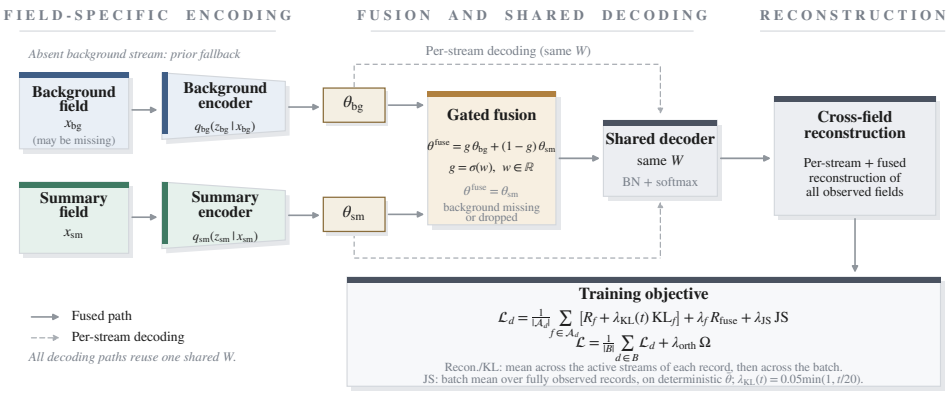


Fig. 2 Overview of FC-NTM. Each field has its own conditional variational stream. Solid arrows show the fused path, in which the gated mixture is decoded and every present field is reconstructed; dashed arrows show the per-stream decodes, which reuse the same decoder parameters. The training objective combines per-stream reconstruction, the KL terms of the active streams, fused reconstruction, the JS term (computed only when both streams are active) and the topic-orthogonality penalty. A missing or dropped field falls back to the prior, so the gated mixture reduces to the remaining stream ($\theta^{\text{fuse}} = \theta_{\text{sm}}$ when the background field is missing or dropped). The β read-out uses the raw matrix W, whereas generation follows the batch-normalised path of Eq. (2).

Text mining and topic modelling of engineering documents.

Within engineering informatics the text-mining literature is extensive — safety reports Tixier et al. (2016); Zhang et al. (2019), regulatory and contractual documents Salama and El-Gohary (2016); Zhou and El-Gohary (2016); Moon et al. (2022); Pham and Han (2023), domain surveys Wu et al. (2022); Shamshiri et al. (2024) — and topic models appear in it as DUET Wang and Taylor (2019), as a study of machine-learning applications in buildings Zhou et al. (2025) and as passport taxonomies Vangelova et al. (2026). All of it treats a record as one flat text. The question taken up here is different: what the record's fixed field structure does to field-restricted read-out and to missing-field inference.

3 Methodology

Figure 2 gives an overview of FC-NTM. The two fields are encoded by separate conditional variational streams that share one topic decoder; the streams are tied by cross-field reconstruction and a consistency term, and field-level masking with whole-field dropout covers partially and fully missing fields.

3.1 Problem setting

Each record d consists of a *background* field (e.g. the abstract of a paper or the body of an issue) and a *summary* field (e.g. the title), with N records in total and a shared evaluation vocabulary of V terms. The model maintains K topics, a document–topic distribution $\theta_d \in \Delta^{K-1}$, and a topic–word matrix $\beta \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times V}$ shared by both fields. The task is to infer θ_d and β from unlabelled records, to produce readable topics under

two read-outs, and to keep the model usable when one field is partially or entirely missing at inference time.

3.2 Field streams and the shared decoder

Each field is encoded by its own two-layer MLP encoder (200 hidden units, Softplus activations, dropout rate 0.2) into the parameters of a field-conditioned Gaussian posterior,

$$q_f(z_f \mid x_f) = \mathcal{N}\big(\mu_f(x_f), \mathrm{diag}(\sigma_f^2(x_f))\big), \qquad f \in \{\mathrm{bg}, \mathrm{sm}\}, \tag{1}$$

where x_f is the L_1-normalised bag of words of field f and $\log \sigma_f^2$ is capped at 2. Posterior means are mapped to topic proportions by a deterministic softmax, $\bar{\theta}_f = \mathrm{softmax}(\mu_f(x_f))$, which replaces sampling at evaluation time. Note that $\bar{\theta}_f$ is a point estimate of the topic proportions and does not equal the expectation of $\mathrm{softmax}(z_f)$. Both streams share one linear topic–word matrix $W \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times V}$, and we write $\theta_f \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times K}$ for the topic proportions of field f under the row-vector convention,

$$p(w \mid \theta_f) = \mathrm{softmax}\big(\mathrm{BN}(\theta_f W)\big), \tag{2}$$

where θ_f passes through dropout before the product, BN is a batch-normalisation layer *without* affine parameters applied over the vocabulary dimension (batch statistics during training, running statistics at evaluation), and there is no additive bias. The β read-out of Section 3.6 reads the raw rows of W, whereas generation uses the normalised path of Eq. (2). Section 3.6 discusses the difference between the two.

3.3 Training objective

For a document d let $\mathcal{G}_d$ collect its present fields (the background field is present when the record carries it; the summary stream is always instantiated, including zero-vector inputs after preprocessing) and let $\mathcal{A}_d \subseteq \mathcal{G}_d$ be the *active streams*, i.e. present fields whose stream is not removed by whole-field dropout. Write $n_{dw}^{(g)}$ for the raw count of word w in field g. Each active stream decodes once (Eq. (2)) and reconstructs *every present field*,

$$R_f = \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_d} \omega_g \, R_f(g), \qquad R_f(g) = -\sum_{w=1}^{V} n_{dw}^{(g)} \log p(w \mid \theta_f)\,, \tag{3}$$

with fixed field weights $\omega_{\mathrm{bg}} = 2.0$ and $\omega_{\mathrm{sm}} = 1.0$. The summary stream also reconstructs the background field (cross-field reconstruction). A background field that is observed but dropped during training remains a reconstruction target even though its own stream is inactive, whereas a naturally missing background field enters neither the inputs nor the targets. The per-document objective is

$$\mathcal{L}_d = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{A}_d|} \sum_{f \in \mathcal{A}_d} \Big[R_f + \lambda_{\mathrm{KL}}(t)\, \mathrm{KL}_f \Big] + \lambda_f R_{\mathrm{fuse}} + \lambda_{\mathrm{JS}}\, \mathrm{JS}, \tag{4}$$

where $\mathrm{KL}_f = \mathrm{KL}\big(q_f(z_f \mid x_f) \,\|\, \mathcal{N}(0, I)\big)$ is summed over the K latent dimensions and clamped at zero, and $\lambda_{\mathrm{KL}}(t) = 0.05 \min(1, t/20)$ anneals linearly during the first 20 epochs. The fused term $R_{\mathrm{fuse}} = \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}_d} \omega_g R_{\mathrm{fuse}}(g)$ is a second reconstruction of both present fields from the fused topic mixture

$$\theta_d^{\mathrm{fuse}} = g\,\theta_{\mathrm{bg}} + (1-g)\,\theta_{\mathrm{sm}}, \qquad g = \sigma(w), \quad w \in \mathbb{R}. \tag{5}$$

for records with both fields present, and $\theta_d^{\mathrm{fuse}} = \theta_{\mathrm{sm}}$ when the background field is missing or dropped. During training Eq. (5) combines the *sampled* per-stream proportions that also feed the per-stream reconstructions; at inference time, and for the JS term below, the deterministic estimates $\bar{\theta}_f$ are used, so that Eq. (5) becomes a convex combination of two point estimates. We refer to this quantity as a *fused topic mixture* to distinguish it from a posterior. The gate g receives gradients only through R_{fuse}, so with $\lambda_f = 0$ the model degenerates exactly to fixed mean fusion. The consistency term

$$\mathrm{JS} = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{KL}\big(\bar{\theta}_{\mathrm{bg}} \| m\big) + \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{KL}\big(\bar{\theta}_{\mathrm{sm}} \| m\big), \qquad m = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(\bar{\theta}_{\mathrm{bg}} + \bar{\theta}_{\mathrm{sm}}\big), \tag{6}$$

acts on the deterministic topic proportions and does not use the Gaussian posteriors. It is computed only for documents whose two streams are both active and is not applied to records with one active stream. A topic-orthogonality penalty keeps the rows of W apart,

$$\Omega = \frac{1}{K(K-1)} \sum_{k \neq k'} \big|\cos\langle W_k, W_{k'}\rangle\big|, \tag{7}$$

and the batch objective is $\frac{1}{|B|}\sum_{d \in B} \mathcal{L}_d + \lambda_{\mathrm{orth}}\Omega$ with $\lambda_{\mathrm{orth}} = 0.2$.

3.4 Field masking

Two masking mechanisms expose the model to missing fields, and they act on different units: word types during training, token positions at test time (Section 5.5). (i) *Word-level input dropout* (denoising) is applied during training to the bag-of-words *word types* of each field: each bag-of-words dimension is independently zeroed with probability 0.30 (background) or 0.40 (summary) in the encoder view only, while the reconstruction targets remain the complete counts. (ii) *Whole-field dropout* removes the background stream of each training document with probability 0.5 and substitutes the prior; the summary stream is never dropped and learns to reconstruct both fields on its own. The consistency weight $\lambda_{\mathrm{JS}} = 0.5$, the fusion weight $\lambda_f = 0.5$ and the dropout probabilities were selected on held-out data.

3.5 Optimisation

Training uses Adam (learning rate 5×10^{-4}; exponential decay rates $\beta_1 = 0.9$ and $\beta_2 = 0.999$), mini-batches of 128, gradient-norm clipping at 5.0 and a budget of 700 epochs. After the KL warm-up the state with the lowest held-out loss is kept, for which 20% of the training split is held out; the patience is 150 epochs. Evaluation-mode inference is deterministic: the reparameterisation sampling is switched off and the held-out loss uses posterior means. Numerical-anomaly recovery rolls the weights

back to the most recent finite epoch, clears the optimiser moments and halves the learning rate; this recovery step is separate from the best-held-out-epoch selection of the early-stopping loop.

3.6 Unified topic–word read-out

Topic-word comparisons are only meaningful if every model is read out with the same vocabulary and the same number of words per topic. We fix one evaluation vocabulary and exactly ten words per topic. The β **read-out** takes the top ten words of each normalised row of the model's topic–word matrix; for FC-NTM these are the raw rows of W, whereas generation uses Eq. (2). LDA, BTM, NMF, ProdLDA, ETM, CTM-lite, CombinedTM and FC-NTM are all evaluated this way. The **class TF–IDF read-out** aggregates the training-term counts by the soft document–topic assignment of the model, applies a BERTopic-style class TF–IDF transform Grootendorst (2022), and then takes the top ten words. Soft assignments replace the hard cluster membership used in the standard class-level aggregation; for FC-NTM this read-out is built from the fused topic mixture $\bar{\theta}^{\text{fuse}}$, which is why the two read-outs can rank models differently. The sensitivity of the raw-parameter read-out relative to the generative read-out is reported in the Supplementary Material.

4 Experimental setup

4.1 Corpora and evaluation protocol

We use three dual-field corpora. The **civil engineering corpus** is the application corpus: title–abstract records of English-language scholarly works from OpenAlex Priem et al. (2022) (https://openalex.org) in *Civil and Structural Engineering* and *Building and Construction* (2000–2023; CC BY, CC BY-SA, or public-domain records). The sample comprises 7,102 articles, 889 conference papers and 9 reviews, split into 6,000 training and 2,000 test records, with the title as the summary field and the abstract as the background field (mean length ratio 11.2). **GitHub issues** OpenIndex (2026) pairs the issue body with its title (four mature repositories, 6,000/2,000, ratio 12.9), and **AG News** Zhang et al. (2015) pairs the description with the headline (6,000/7,600, ratio 3.9). All corpora are lower-cased and tokenised on letter sequences; stop words and very short tokens are removed, the vocabulary is built from the training split only, and test records never enter the vocabulary. Tables 1 and 2 report the two public corpora and Table 3 the application corpus, all on the same evaluation vocabulary with exactly ten words per topic and $K = 30$. The evaluation protocol (vocabulary, ten words per topic, coherence and diversity metrics) is shared by every model, whereas the training procedure differs across algorithm families and is described in Section 4.2. Because 400 records from each public test corpus were used during design, every public-corpus result is also recomputed on a development-free subset (1,600 GitHub and 7,200 AG News records). This recomputation removes direct test overlap and is reported as a sensitivity analysis; Section 6 considers the remaining effect of prior model selection. The results are organised around three questions: how well civil title–abstract records can be structured into verifiable topics;

Table 1 Topic quality on AG News under the unified evaluation vocabulary (ten words per topic; values are means over seeds 11/23/37 where applicable; BERTopic and Top2Vec choose their own topic numbers and are shown for reference).

Model	Topics	C_V	NPMI	UMass	$\text{EXCL}_{\text{KADJ}}$	IRBO
BTM	30	0.600±0.011	0.164±0.005	−4.19	0.409	0.980
CombinedTM	30	0.526±0.037	0.057±0.070	−8.01	0.118	1.000
FC-NTM-cTFIDF	30	**0.612**±0.014	**0.173**±0.012	−4.20	0.193	0.974
FC-NTM	30	0.586±0.026	0.137±0.022	−4.91	0.013	0.993
ETM	30	0.506±0.014	0.092±0.010	−5.12	0.439	0.982
ProdLDA	30	0.526±0.031	0.071±0.015	−6.61	0.055	0.999
Top2Vec	2.7	0.498±0.032	0.099±0.031	−2.92	0.268	0.937
NMF	30	0.494±0.015	0.069±0.013	−5.96	0.799	0.997
BERTopic	29	0.488±0.022	0.035±0.026	−8.81	0.681	0.997
CTM-lite	30	0.431±0.023	−0.015±0.016	−8.34	0.041	0.998
LDA	30	0.421±0.013	−0.066±0.018	−8.62	0.696	0.994

Table 2 Topic quality on GitHub issues (same evaluation protocol and read-outs as Table 1; values are means over seeds 11/23/37; BERTopic and Top2Vec choose their own topic numbers and are shown for reference).

Model	Topics	C_V	NPMI	UMass	$\text{EXCL}_{\text{KADJ}}$	IRBO
BTM	30	0.712±0.012	0.232±0.012	−1.79	0.349	0.934
FC-NTM-cTFIDF	30	**0.727**±0.022	**0.274**±0.026	−1.90	0.133	0.901
FC-NTM	30	0.701±0.016	0.233±0.012	−3.16	0.010	0.967
ETM	30	0.675±0.014	0.213±0.010	−2.14	0.366	0.955
CombinedTM	30	0.643±0.022	0.193±0.015	−4.70	0.031	0.983
NMF	30	0.614±0.005	0.164±0.003	−3.26	0.595	0.985
ProdLDA	30	0.579±0.007	0.107±0.012	−5.21	0.043	0.995
CTM-lite	30	0.585±0.032	0.129±0.036	−5.11	0.011	0.989
LDA	30	0.546±0.011	0.074±0.017	−4.21	0.684	0.990
BERTopic	29	0.540±0.015	0.076±0.012	−7.00	0.546	0.976
Top2Vec	160	0.493±0.009	−0.008±0.013	−9.65	0.337	0.994

how much signal remains when the abstract is missing; and how much the complete field-cooperative configuration adds over a concatenated single-encoder control. Cross-corpus diagnostics complete the analysis.

4.2 Baselines, training protocols and metrics

Baselines are LDA Blei et al. (2003), BTM Yan et al. (2013), NMF with a KL objective Lee and Seung (2001), ProdLDA Srivastava and Sutton (2017), ETM Dieng et al.

Table 3 Topic quality on the civil engineering corpus under the unified evaluation vocabulary (ten words per topic; values are means over seeds 11/23/37; BERTopic and Top2Vec choose their own topic numbers and are shown for reference).

Model	Topics	C_V	NPMI	UMass	$\text{EXCL}_{\text{KADJ}}$	IRBO
BTM	30	0.583±0.010	0.128±0.009	−2.18	0.283	0.944
CombinedTM	30	0.539±0.029	0.082±0.028	−6.11	0.063	0.998
FC-NTM-cTFIDF	30	**0.636**±0.014	**0.159**±0.011	−2.21	0.165	0.937
FC-NTM	30	0.633±0.014	0.154±0.022	−2.85	0.014	0.990
ETM	30	0.581±0.012	0.119±0.007	−2.75	0.379	0.963
ProdLDA	30	0.580±0.023	0.125±0.017	−3.84	0.051	0.999
Top2Vec	153	0.515±0.002	0.029±0.011	−8.52	0.359	0.995
NMF	30	0.598±0.009	0.135±0.006	−2.86	0.559	0.984
BERTopic	29	0.576±0.026	0.116±0.027	−5.06	0.563	0.991
CTM-lite	30	0.536±0.030	0.098±0.027	−3.85	0.013	0.995
LDA	30	0.554±0.008	0.056±0.025	−4.62	0.602	0.987

(2020), CTM-lite, the official CombinedTM Bianchi et al. (2021), BERTopic Grootendorst (2022) and Top2Vec Angelov (2020); contextual models use Sentence-BERT embeddings Reimers and Gurevych (2019). The implementations fall into four families with different training procedures: Gibbs sampling (BTM, LDA), matrix factorisation (NMF), neural variational models (ProdLDA, ETM, CTM-lite and FC-NTM share the Adam loop Kingma and Ba (2015) and the 700-epoch budget but differ in learning rate; the official CombinedTM keeps its own loop), and embedding clustering (BERTopic, Top2Vec), which choose their own topic numbers and are shown for reference only. Full hyper-parameters are listed in the Supplementary Material. Topic quality is measured in three families. Coherence is reported as C_V Röder et al. (2015), NPMI Bouma (2009); Lau et al. (2014) and UMass Newman et al. (2010); Mimno et al. (2011). Diversity is one minus the mean rank-biased overlap (RBO) Webber et al. (2010), computed with persistence 0.9 and the residual tail retained for fixed ten-word lists. Exclusivity follows Bischof and Airoldi Bischof and Airoldi (2012) and is normalised by K, so that zero corresponds to the chance level $1/K$. Topics with non-finite scores are discarded, and the effective number of topics is reported alongside every score.

5 Results and discussion

5.1 Main results

On the civil engineering corpus (Table 3), FC-NTM attains the highest coherence of all models evaluated under both read-outs ($C_V = 0.633$ for the β read-out and 0.636 for the class TF–IDF read-out; NPMI 0.154 and 0.159 over seeds 11/23/37). It is followed by NMF (0.598) and BTM (0.583), and it is ahead of every neural baseline. The ten-seed extension preserves both read-out advantages (Table 5), and Figure 3 shows the per-seed differences behind these means across all three corpora.

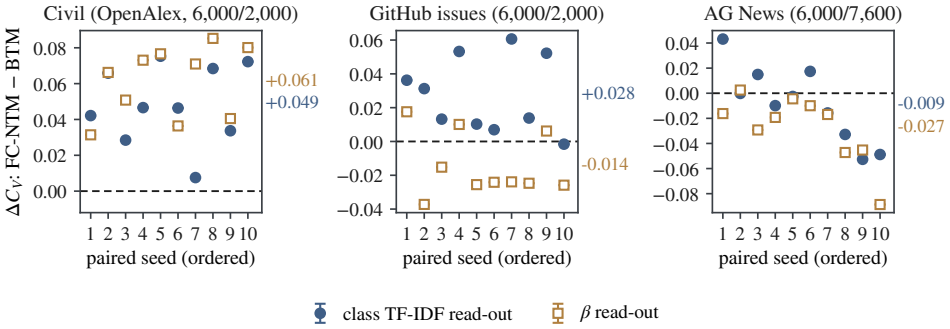


Fig. 3 Per-seed paired comparison of FC-NTM and BTM (ten seeds per corpus, C_V). Each point is one paired seed; the dashed line marks the BTM level. The class TF–IDF read-out is positive in all ten paired seeds on the civil corpus and in nine of ten on GitHub issues, whereas the AG News seeds are mixed. This is the corpus-dependent pattern that the mean differences summarise.

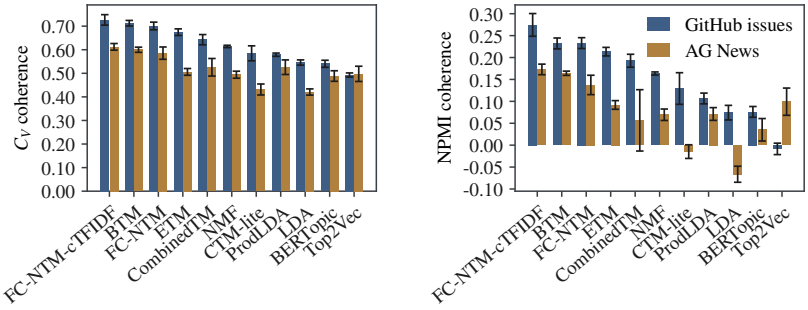


Fig. 4 Main results on the two public corpora (unified evaluation vocabulary, ten words per topic). Left: C_V; right: NPMI. Error bars are standard deviations across seeds 11/23/37.

Figure 4 compares all evaluated models on the two public corpora under both coherence metrics. On AG News, FC-NTM-cTFIDF reaches $C_V = 0.612$ and NPMI $= 0.173$, above BTM under the matched class TF–IDF read-out (0.593 / 0.169) and above the β read-outs of ProdLDA, ETM, NMF, CTM-lite and LDA; under its own β read-out BTM keeps a small lead (0.600 versus 0.586). On GitHub issues, FC-NTM-cTFIDF records $C_V = 0.727$ and NPMI $= 0.274$, above BTM at both read-outs (0.712 / 0.232 for the β read-out, 0.700 / 0.235 matched), and above the sentence-embedding baselines (CombinedTM 0.643, BERTopic 0.540).

The matched-read-out advantage over BTM is +0.027 C_V and +0.039 NPMI on GitHub and +0.019 / +0.004 on AG News for three seeds, but the per-seed structure differs: on GitHub all three seeds are positive, whereas on AG News the mean difference rests on two of the three seeds and the NPMI advantage on a single seed. On the development-free test subset the ordering is unchanged (GitHub 0.734 versus 0.711, NPMI 0.284 versus 0.248; AG News 0.610 versus 0.590, NPMI 0.172 versus 0.167; with BTM's β read-out, 0.734 versus 0.726 and 0.610 versus 0.598).

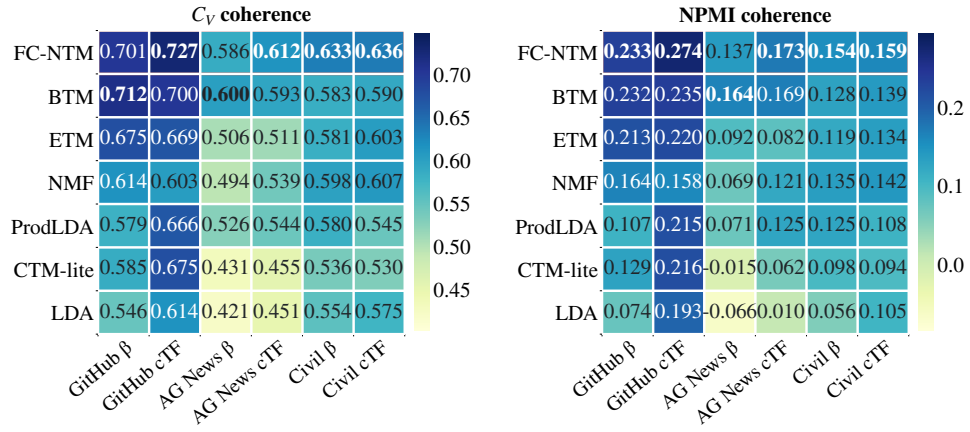


Fig. 5 The read-out comparison of Table 4 as a heatmap ($K = 30$, means over seeds 11/23/37). Left: C_V; right: NPMI. Columns combine the three corpora with the two read-outs (β read-out; class TF–IDF). The boxed first row is FC-NTM; bold entries mark the column-wise best.

5.2 Read-out-matched comparison

Table 4 collects the read-out-matched comparison across models and read-outs.

The class TF–IDF read-out depends on the model and the corpus: on GitHub it lifts CTM-lite, ProdLDA and LDA by 0.091, 0.087 and 0.068 but leaves ETM and NMF unchanged or worse, while on AG News it helps every model except BTM. Comparisons use the matched read-out. Under it, FC-NTM-cTFIDF leads the strongest GitHub baselines (BTM 0.700, CTM-lite 0.675, ETM 0.669, ProdLDA 0.666) by 0.027–0.061 C_V and 0.039–0.059 NPMI, larger than its seed-to-seed standard deviation (0.022); on AG News the advantage over BTM is +0.019 C_V but rests on two of three seeds; under the β read-out the AG News means are 0.586 for FC-NTM and 0.600 for BTM. On the civil corpus NMF (0.607) and ETM (0.603) exceed BTM (0.590), and FC-NTM-cTFIDF leads them by 0.029 and 0.033 C_V, although the ten-seed comparison is against BTM. Figure 5 visualises the same comparison.

5.3 Ten-seed paired comparison

To test whether the three-seed differences are seed noise, we extend FC-NTM and BTM to ten seeds on all three corpora, adding seeds 53, 71, 89, 101, 113, 127 and 139, and compare both read-outs and the occlusion behaviour seed by seed. Occlusion comparisons are limited to preselected baselines: BTM on all three corpora and LDA additionally on AG News.

For GitHub, the class TF–IDF difference is +0.028 C_V (95% CI $[+0.012, +0.043]$, 9/10 positive seeds), and the relative-degradation difference is +0.024 (10/10). On the civil corpus, the class TF–IDF and β read-out differences are +0.049 and +0.061 C_V, with 10/10 positive paired differences; the occlusion difference is −0.003 (0/10). On AG News, the class TF–IDF difference is −0.009 (95% CI $[-0.030, +0.013]$, 3/10) and the β read-out difference is −0.027 (1/10). The β read-out difference on GitHub is −0.014 (3/10). The class TF–IDF mean differences across the three corpora

Table 4 Read-out comparison ($K = 30$, means over seeds 11/23/37). Each model is first read out through its own topic–word matrix (β read-out) and then through a class TF–IDF read-out aggregated from its training-set posterior θ; BTM enters the same read-out through the point-estimate document–topic posterior of its original Section 3.3, and the FC-NTM row is the same model as in Tables 1 and 2.

Corpus	Model	β read-out C_V / NPMI	Class TF–IDF C_V / NPMI
GitHub	FC-NTM(3 seed mean)	0.701 / 0.233	**0.727 / 0.274**
	ETM	0.675 / 0.213	0.669 / 0.220
	ProdLDA	0.579 / 0.107	0.666 / 0.215
	CTM-lite	0.585 / 0.129	0.675 / 0.216
	NMF	0.614 / 0.164	0.603 / 0.158
	LDA	0.546 / 0.074	0.614 / 0.193
	BTM(3 seeds)	0.712 / 0.232	0.700 / 0.235
AG News	FC-NTM(3 seed mean)	0.586 / 0.137	**0.612 / 0.173**
	ProdLDA	0.526 / 0.071	0.544 / 0.125
	NMF	0.494 / 0.069	0.539 / 0.121
	ETM	0.506 / 0.092	0.511 / 0.082
	CTM-lite	0.431 / −0.015	0.455 / 0.062
	LDA	0.421 / −0.066	0.451 / 0.010
	BTM(3 seeds)	0.600 / 0.164	0.593 / 0.169
Civil corpus	FC-NTM(3 seed mean)	**0.633 / 0.154**	**0.636 / 0.159**
	NMF	0.598 / 0.135	0.607 / 0.142
	ETM	0.581 / 0.119	0.603 / 0.134
	BTM(3 seeds)	0.583 / 0.128	0.590 / 0.139
	LDA	0.554 / 0.056	0.575 / 0.105
	ProdLDA	0.580 / 0.125	0.545 / 0.108
	CTM-lite	0.536 / 0.098	0.530 / 0.094

Table 5 Ten-seed paired comparison of FC-NTM and BTM on the three corpora. The read-out rows report C_V differences (FC-NTM minus BTM at the same read-out); the occlusion rows compare the relative degradation NLL(100%)/NLL(25%), so a positive value means FC-NTM is more stable. Occlusion comparisons are limited to preselected baselines: BTM on all three corpora and LDA additionally on AG News. CIs are two-sided 95% t-based confidence intervals; sign and Wilcoxon tests are two-sided.

Corpus	Comparison	Mean diff.	CI low	CI high	Positive	Sign p	Wilcoxon p
GitHub	Class TF–IDF	+0.028	+0.012	+0.043	9/10	0.021	0.004
GitHub	β read-out	−0.014	−0.028	−0.001	3/10	0.344	0.037
GitHub	Occlusion (vs. BTM)	+0.024	+0.022	+0.026	10/10	0.002	0.002
AG News	Class TF–IDF	−0.009	−0.030	+0.013	3/10	0.344	0.375
AG News	β read-out	−0.027	−0.047	−0.008	1/10	0.021	0.004
AG News	Occlusion (vs. BTM)	+0.025	+0.024	+0.026	10/10	0.002	0.002
AG News	Occlusion (vs. LDA)	−0.013	−0.014	−0.012	0/10	0.002	0.002
Civil corpus	Class TF–IDF	+0.049	+0.033	+0.064	10/10	0.002	0.002
Civil corpus	β read-out	+0.061	+0.047	+0.075	10/10	0.002	0.002
Civil corpus	Occlusion (vs. BTM)	−0.003	−0.004	−0.002	0/10	0.002	0.002

are +0.049, +0.028 and −0.009. Confidence intervals describe training and masking randomness under a fixed corpus and design.

Table 6 Field redundancy, measured occlusion gap and the C_V difference against BTM on two corpora. Redundancy is fitted on the training split and evaluated on the test split and includes constructive controls (exact copy = 1.000, cross-document shuffle ≈ 0.000); the occlusion ΔC_V is the mean±standard deviation over seeds 11/23/37 with dropout training. The last column gives the C_V difference under the matched class TF–IDF read-out and under BTM's β read-out.

Corpus	Held-out Ridge R^2	Held-out ρ^2_{cca}	Occlusion ΔC_V	C_V gap, cTFIDF−BTM (matched / β)
GitHub issues	0.230	0.306	+0.009±0.022	+0.027 / +0.014
AG News	0.158	0.245	+0.018±0.013	+0.019 / +0.012

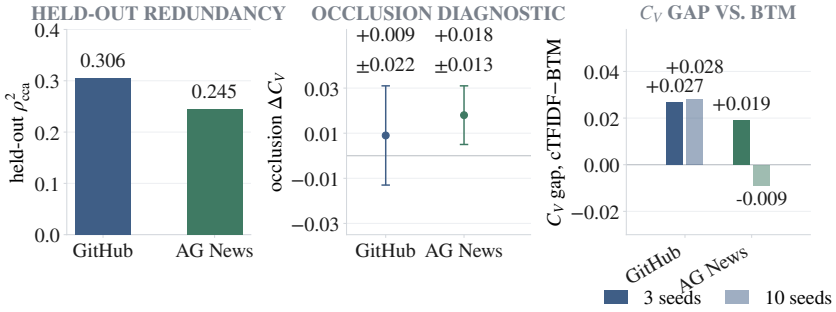


Fig. 6 Field redundancy and gain (held-out measures). Left: squared canonical correlation ρ^2_{cca} (higher means more redundant), fitted on the training split and evaluated on the test split. Middle: occlusion diagnostic ΔC_V (mean±standard deviation over seeds 11/23/37). Right: the C_V difference of FC-NTM-cTFIDF against BTM under the matched class TF–IDF read-out (three seeds) and the ten-seed paired difference. The two corpora reach similar held-out redundancy, while the ten-seed difference is +0.028 on GitHub and −0.009 on AG News.

5.4 Field redundancy and the gain

Table 6 reports the held-out redundancy measures together with the observed gains, and Figure 6 relates them across the two public corpora.

The redundancy measures are fitted on the training split and evaluated on the test split for the two public corpora. Their held-out predictability is 0.306 for GitHub and 0.245 for AG News (ρ^2_{cca}). At three seeds, the matched class TF–IDF differences from BTM are +0.027 and +0.019; the ten-seed differences are +0.028 (9/10) and −0.009 (3/10). The corresponding civil difference is +0.049 (10/10), as reported in Table 5. Whole-field occlusion changes coherence by $+0.009 \pm 0.022$ on GitHub and $+0.018 \pm 0.013$ on AG News.

5.5 Field inference under partial occlusion

A direct test of field complementarity is whether the visible summary field helps a model recover content when part of the background field is unavailable. The protocol (Supplementary Material) masks a fraction p of the background-field tokens in the test documents, re-infers the topic proportions from the remaining input, and scores

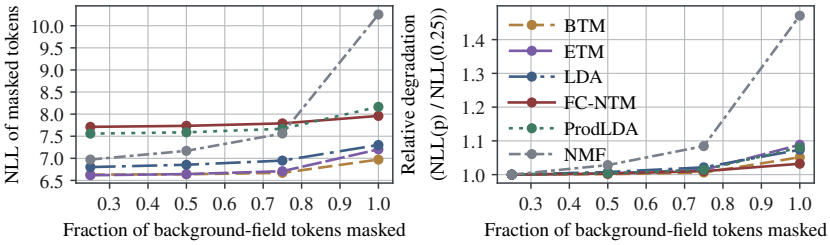


Fig. 7 Inference behaviour under partial occlusion of the background field (GitHub issues, seed 11, 2,000 test documents). Left: per-token negative log-likelihood of the occluded tokens; right: relative degradation NLL(p)/NLL(0.25), which summarises the relative increase from the 25% condition. FC-NTM, trained with whole-field dropout at $p = 0.5$, shows the smallest relative degradation ($\times 1.032$). The figure also reports absolute NLL to contextualise this ratio; topic agreement is reported in Table 7.

Table 7 Partial-occlusion curves on GitHub issues (seed 11). NLL is the per-token negative log-likelihood of the occluded tokens (lower is better); relative degradation is NLL(100%)/NLL(25%); agreement is the fraction of documents holding their most probable topic at 100% occlusion. BTM enters through its document–topic posterior.

Model	NLL(25%)	NLL(50%)	NLL(75%)	NLL(100%)	Degradation / Agreement
FC-NTM	7.712	7.735	7.790	7.960	**1.032** / 0.358
LDA	6.802	6.854	6.948	7.302	1.074 / 0.420
ProdLDA	7.558	7.588	7.668	8.165	1.080 / 0.354
BTM	6.630	6.639	6.670	**6.972**	1.052 / 0.448
ETM	**6.616**	6.643	6.708	7.202	1.089 / 0.452
NMF	6.972	7.169	7.561	10.255	1.471 / **0.469**

the occluded tokens under the model's own word distribution; it reports the per-token negative log-likelihood (NLL), the agreement of the most probable topic with the unoccluded inference, and the posterior JS divergence. Every model uses its own inference path and its own word distribution, so no cross-model read-out convention is involved. When a document has no visible evidence at all, BTM and NMF use the training-corpus topic prior; treating a zero vector as a word distribution would inflate the NLL to $\log 10^{12} = 27.63$. Table 7 reports the per-condition values on GitHub issues, and Figure 7 plots the NLL and relative-degradation curves behind them.

From 25% to 100% occlusion the per-token NLL of FC-NTM rises by only 3.2% (7.712 → 7.960), less than LDA (7.4%), ProdLDA (8.0%), ETM (8.9%), BTM (5.2%) and NMF (47.1%), which is consistent with the training-time whole-field dropout. At full occlusion, BTM has the lowest NLL (6.972); topic agreement is highest for NMF (0.469), followed by ETM (0.452), while FC-NTM reaches 0.358. Relative degradation is therefore always read alongside absolute NLL and agreement, because the ratio alone says nothing about how good the absolute predictions are. The protocol covers three English corpora, ten seeds per corpus, occlusion masks redrawn for every seed, and the field split follows the existing title/body structure.

Table 8 Partial-occlusion behaviour on the three corpora (ten seeds 11–139, mean±standard deviation; the mask is redrawn per seed). Bold marks the smallest relative degradation per corpus. Field asymmetry is described by the mean background/summary token ratio and by the token-type share of background words that do not occur in the summary of the same document.

Corpus(Field asymmetry)	Model	Relative degradation	Agreement(100%)
GitHub issues Length ratio 12.9 Background-exclusive 0.877	FC-NTM	**1.028±0.003**	0.364
	LDA	1.075±0.003	0.416
	ProdLDA	1.078±0.004	0.343
	ETM	1.087±0.003	0.451
	BTM	1.052±0.001	0.443
	NMF	1.467±0.009	0.464
Civil corpus Length ratio 11.2 Background-exclusive 0.894	FC-NTM	1.010±0.001	0.661
	LDA	1.037±0.002	0.574
	ProdLDA	1.028±0.002	0.558
	ETM	1.041±0.001	0.656
	BTM	**1.007±0.001**	0.565
	NMF	1.172±0.002	0.651
AG News Length ratio 3.9 Background-exclusive 0.868	FC-NTM	1.019±0.001	0.515
	LDA	**1.006±0.002**	0.440
	ProdLDA	1.026±0.001	0.491
	ETM	1.072±0.002	0.561
	BTM	1.044±0.001	0.553
	NMF	1.411±0.004	0.545

5.6 Cross-corpus comparison

Table 8 and Figure 8 extend the same protocol to the three corpora.

On GitHub (ratio 12.9), all models degrade by factors of ×1.028–×1.467, and FC-NTM has the smallest relative degradation; the ten-seed paired difference from BTM is +0.024±0.004 (10/10). On the civil corpus (ratio 11.2), the relative degradations are 1.010 for FC-NTM and 1.007 for BTM (paired difference −0.003, 0/10). On AG News (ratio 3.9), they are 1.019 for FC-NTM and 1.006 for LDA. Held-out mutual prediction is slightly higher for GitHub, while the length ratio and background-exclusive share distinguish GitHub from AG News and place the civil corpus in a similar range to GitHub. These statistics serve as corpus descriptors for the three evaluated collections.

5.7 Field-restricted read-out

Field-restricted read-out truncates the topic words to one field's vocabulary and scores them against that field's own test text. With the shared decoder, the background-view C_V of FC-NTM stays close to its full-vocabulary β read-out on all three corpora (0.697, 0.566 and 0.637 versus 0.701, 0.586 and 0.633), while the summary view is lower in absolute terms mainly because a summary contains only 3–5 tokens and the reference corpus is very short, so that column should be compared within the same protocol. The cross-model comparison shows that the read-out is not unique to a two-stream encoder: BTM is slightly better in the background view on GitHub and AG News (0.710 versus 0.697 and 0.586 versus 0.566), FC-NTM leads on the civil corpus (0.637 versus 0.600 for NMF), and in the summary view LDA and ProdLDA are above

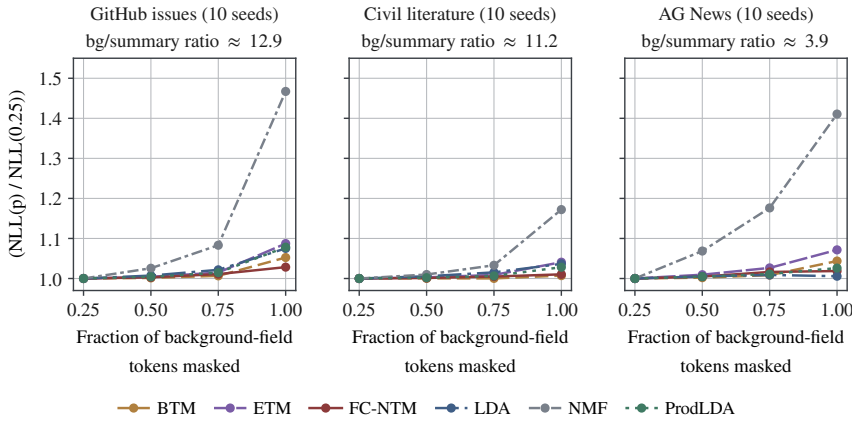


Fig. 8 Relative degradation under the same partial-occlusion protocol on three corpora (curves are means, shading is ±1 standard deviation; all six models cover the ten seeds 11–139). Left: GitHub issues (background to summary length ratio ≈ 12.9); middle: civil engineering corpus (≈ 11.2); right: AG News (≈ 3.9). Only on GitHub is the degradation of FC-NTM below all baselines; on the civil corpus and AG News the smallest degradation belongs to BTM and LDA respectively, and the gap to FC-NTM is within 0.003–0.013.

FC-NTM on all three corpora (0.486 and 0.438 versus 0.423 on AG News). The field view thus serves as a descriptive read-out available to any model with a topic–word matrix.

5.8 Ablation: fusion reconstruction and gating

The three-step ablation separates two questions: whether the fused mixture receives its own reconstruction term, and whether fusion is averaged or gated. The fusion-reconstruction term is effective, but only for the read-out that uses the fused posterior: adding it under mean fusion raises the class TF–IDF C_V and NPMI by 0.014 and 0.013 (3/3 seeds) while lowering the β read-out by 0.013 and 0.021. Replacing mean fusion by a gate brings no further gain on this corpus (class TF–IDF differences -0.001 and -0.000, 1/3 seeds; β read-out -0.007 and -0.012, 0/3): once the fusion-reconstruction term is present, the gate adds nothing over mean fusion.

5.9 Ablation: core components

Four components are switched off one at a time. First, removing the JS consistency term causes no consistent change in topic quality on any corpus or read-out (all six cells $|\Delta C_V| \leq 0.004$, none with a clear positive paired majority): in this parameterisation the fused representation is trained by the fusion-reconstruction objective, not by pulling the two posteriors together. Second, the observed effect of cross-field reconstruction and word masking depends on the corpus: on GitHub, removing cross-field reconstruction even raises the β read-out by 0.021 (2/3 seeds) and costs only 0.005 in the class TF–IDF read-out, while on AG News and the civil corpus both read-outs drop when either component is removed (cross-field reconstruction $-0.011/-0.022$ and $-0.022/-0.019$; word masking $-0.026/-0.043$ and $-0.010/-0.012$, with all

Table 9 Field-restricted read-out (C_V, mean±standard deviation over seeds 11/23/37). Every topic–word matrix is truncated to the vocabulary of one field and scored against that field's test text only; "background view" is the abstract/body side and "summary view" the title side. FC-NTM's summary view is scored on 20–22 scorable topics per seed on GitHub (29–30 on AG News, 26–28 on the civil corpus) because topics whose ten field words never occur in the held-out text get an undefined C_V.

Corpus	Model	Background view C_V	Summary view C_V
GitHub issues	FC-NTM	0.697±0.016	0.426±0.012
	BTM	**0.710±0.011**	0.396±0.018
	NMF	0.609±0.004	0.433±0.002
	LDA	0.543±0.011	0.466±0.005
	ProdLDA	0.575±0.006	**0.467±0.034**
AG News	FC-NTM	0.566±0.016	0.423±0.015
	BTM	**0.586±0.015**	0.399±0.018
	NMF	0.477±0.015	0.444±0.002
	LDA	0.419±0.007	**0.486±0.006**
	ProdLDA	0.499±0.032	0.438±0.007
Civil corpus	FC-NTM	**0.637±0.015**	0.408±0.005
	BTM	0.589±0.014	0.382±0.008
	NMF	0.600±0.009	0.398±0.013
	LDA	0.554±0.008	0.415±0.006
	ProdLDA	0.576±0.025	**0.419±0.012**

class TF–IDF columns at 0/3). Third, whole-field dropout acts mostly on the class TF–IDF read-out and is consistently beneficial on two of the three corpora only: it lowers both read-outs on GitHub and AG News but changes the β read-out of the civil corpus by only +0.001 while lowering its class TF–IDF read-out by 0.034.

These component-level differences are not explained by field asymmetry: the civil corpus has almost the same length ratio as GitHub (11.2 versus 12.9) yet behaves like AG News (3.9).

5.10 Sensitivity to the fusion weight

At $\lambda_f = 0.25$ the class TF–IDF read-out is essentially the no-fusion result (C_V 0.713 versus 0.714) while the β read-out has already dropped by 0.024; between 0.5 and 1.0 the class TF–IDF gain is stable (0.727 versus 0.723, NPMI 0.274 versus 0.277, differences below 0.005), and the β penalty narrows from -0.020 to -0.005 relative to $\lambda_f = 0$. The value 0.5 used throughout is therefore a conservative compromise.

5.11 Whole-field occlusion

Deleting the background field entirely leaves topic-word coherence almost unchanged (all six cells within ±0.02, with sign flips across seeds on GitHub), so coherence is insensitive to field loss and the information loss is visible in the document-level

Table 10 Three-step fusion ablation on GitHub issues ($K = 30$, seeds 11/23/37, same protocol). Within one read-out each row changes exactly one thing: first the fused mixture θ_{fuse} is decoded into the reconstruction term (mean fusion), then mean fusion is replaced by a learnable gate (the main model). "Positive pairs" counts the seeds whose paired difference against the row above is positive (C_V, NPMI).

Read-out	Configuration	C_V	NPMI	Positive pairs	UMass
β	No fusion	0.721±0.016	0.266±0.012	—	−2.63
	Mean fusion + fusion recon.	0.708±0.016	0.245±0.013	1/3, 0/3	−2.98
	Gated fusion (main model)	0.701±0.016	0.233±0.012	0/3, 0/3	−3.16
cTFIDF	No fusion	0.714±0.001	0.262±0.007	—	−1.86
	Mean fusion + fusion recon.	0.728±0.007	0.275±0.015	3/3, 3/3	−1.91
	Gated fusion (main model)	0.727±0.022	0.274±0.026	1/3, 1/3	−1.90

Table 11 Core-component ablation on three corpora and two read-outs ($K = 30$, seeds 11/23/37, 700-epoch budget, all other settings identical to the main model). Each column switches off one component: cross-field reconstruction of both streams, the JS consistency weight, field-level word masking, and whole-field dropout; the fusion-reconstruction term is kept in all columns. Values are mean paired ΔC_V (negative means the component matters), parentheses count positive pairs.

Corpus	Read-out	−Cross-field recon.	−JS consistency	−Word masking	−Field dropout
GitHub	β	+0.021 (2/3)	−0.001 (1/3)	−0.012 (1/3)	−0.023 (1/3)
GitHub	Class TF-IDF	−0.005 (1/3)	+0.004 (2/3)	−0.004 (1/3)	−0.021 (1/3)
AG News	β	−0.011 (2/3)	+0.003 (1/3)	−0.026 (0/3)	−0.010 (1/3)
AG News	Class TF-IDF	−0.022 (0/3)	−0.002 (1/3)	−0.043 (0/3)	−0.023 (1/3)
Civil corpus	β	−0.022 (0/3)	+0.001 (2/3)	−0.010 (1/3)	+0.001 (1/3)
Civil corpus	Class TF-IDF	−0.019 (0/3)	−0.002 (0/3)	−0.012 (0/3)	−0.034 (0/3)

posterior and the word-level prediction: about 66% (GitHub) and 48% (AG News) of the documents change their most probable topic, and the per-token NLL rises by 0.24/0.23 with dropout training (0.24/0.27 without). The influence of whole-field dropout is concentrated in the posterior distribution and is weaker for word-prediction calibration. It lowers the per-token increase from 0.269 to 0.232 and the posterior JS from 0.060 to 0.049 on AG News, is directionally the same on the civil corpus (0.125→0.103, JS 0.039→0.033), and shows no increase difference on GitHub (0.242 versus 0.241) where only the JS slightly improves. Posterior drift under field loss is reduced on two of the three corpora. We read these measures next to absolute prediction accuracy because they describe different aspects of the same result.

5.12 Concatenated-field single-encoder control

To compare the full method with a single-encoder alternative under the same budget we train a control on the concatenated bag of words $[x_{\text{bg}}; x_{\text{sm}}]$ with the same

Table 12 Sensitivity to the fusion-reconstruction weight λ_f on GitHub issues (gated fusion, seeds 11/23/37). $\lambda_f = 0$ is the no-fusion setting, $\lambda_f = 0.5$ is the value used throughout; all other settings match the main model.

λ_f	β read-out		Class TF–IDF	
	C_V	NPMI	C_V	NPMI
0	0.721±0.016	0.266±0.012	0.714±0.001	0.262±0.007
0.25	0.697±0.015	0.217±0.031	0.713±0.015	0.262±0.004
0.5	0.701±0.016	0.233±0.012	0.727±0.022	0.274±0.026
1.0	0.716±0.012	0.246±0.026	0.723±0.012	0.277±0.018

Table 13 Whole-field occlusion at inference time ($K = 30$, final configuration, 700-epoch budget). ΔC_V is the coherence difference between full-field and occluded inference under the same read-out; ΔNLL is the per-token increase; agreement is the fraction of documents whose most probable topic is unchanged. The two rows of a corpus use the same seeds, isolating the effect of the training-time dropout setting.

Corpus	Training setting	C_V^{full}	C_V^{occ}	ΔC_V	ΔNLL(per token)	Agreement	Mean JS
GitHub	Dropout ($p = 0.5$)	0.727	0.717	+0.009	+0.241	0.345	0.082
	No dropout	0.705	0.725	−0.020	+0.242	0.346	0.092
Civil corpus	Dropout ($p = 0.5$)	0.636	0.627	+0.009	+0.103	0.673	0.033
	No dropout	0.602	0.597	+0.005	+0.125	0.642	0.039
AG News	Dropout ($p = 0.5$)	0.612	0.594	+0.018	+0.232	0.520	0.049
	No dropout	0.589	0.582	+0.007	+0.269	0.498	0.060

shared linear decoder, field weights, KL warm-up and orthogonality penalty; whole-field dropout is emulated by zeroing the background half of the input, and there is no fusion or consistency term. The concatenated input doubles the first encoder layer, keeping the parameter count comparable (a 1.5% difference), and both models use the same budget, vocabulary and read-outs on all three corpora (seeds 11/23/37). Table 15 reports the comparison.

Across the six corpus–read-out cells, the mean C_V differences between FC-NTM and the control range from +0.010 to +0.029, all six cells favour FC-NTM, and the paired majorities run from 1/3 to 3/3. The largest gap is on the civil corpus under the class TF–IDF read-out (+0.029), and title-only routing also favours FC-NTM (0.664 versus 0.653 accuracy). The control can serve field-restricted read-out in the same descriptive sense as any topic model with a topic–word matrix, and it infers title-only records by zeroing the background half of the input. What it does not provide are two separate field posteriors: the per-field posteriors, the fused mixture and the consistency diagnostics of the preceding subsections are defined only for a two-stream configuration, and its missing-background path is an input-level emulation rather than a trained field-level operation. The comparison therefore attributes little of the mean

Table 14 Title-only routing to the 15 most frequent OpenAlex topics of the civil corpus (seeds 11/23/37; 857 test records, coverage 42.9%). The supervised TF–IDF classifier provides a reference point on the same label set.

Method	Input	Accuracy	Macro-F1
TF–IDF logistic regression (supervised)	title	0.810	0.805
FC-NTM	title + abstract	0.719±0.016	0.676±0.032
FC-NTM	title only	0.664±0.004	0.624±0.013
Concatenated control	title only	0.653±0.012	0.614±0.034
BTM	title only	0.600±0.013	0.529±0.043
LDA	title only	0.532±0.039	0.458±0.057

coherence gain to the two-stream structure itself: relative to the classical and neural baselines, most of the gain is already obtained by a single encoder with the same decoder and budget, and the two-stream structure adds +0.010–+0.029 on top. What the additional structure buys is field attribution and native missing-field handling, not a large average gain.

5.13 Title-only routing on the civil corpus

When the abstract of a record is missing, can its title still be routed to an interpretable civil subfield? The evaluation labels are the primary topics that OpenAlex assigns to each record OpenAlex (2026). OpenAlex assigns these labels automatically from the title, abstract and source metadata; the frozen snapshot (topic IDs, fetch date) is released with the code, and the label set is the 15 most frequent topics of the training split, covering 42.9% of the test records (2000-record test split). Every model infers a topic distribution from the title alone; FC-NTM and the control use their missing-background inference path. The topic-to-label mapping is fitted on the same title-only inference and is supervised: each topic receives the majority training label of the documents assigned to it, with the training-label prior as fallback for topics that receive no training document (this occurred for three test records in one run). The pipeline therefore combines an unsupervised representation with a supervised mapping fitted on the training split. Accuracy and macro-F1 are reported per seed. A supervised TF–IDF logistic regression on the same titles provides a reference point, and FC-NTM given both fields marks the upper end.

Title-based routing reaches 0.664 accuracy for FC-NTM, 0.653 for the concatenated control, 0.719 with the full fields and 0.810 for the supervised TF–IDF classifier. The corresponding accuracies for the classical topic models are 0.532 for LDA and 0.600 for BTM. Accuracy and macro-F1 for each seed are reported in Table 14.

6 Discussion and limitations

The results assign the field-aware representation a practical role: one trained model supports field-restricted topic words and keeps inferring topic proportions when the

Table 15 Concatenated-field single-encoder control (seeds 11/23/37; same budget, vocabulary and read-outs). Δ is FC-NTM minus the control, with positive pairs in parentheses.

Corpus	Read-out	FC-NTM	Concatenated	Δ (positive pairs)
GitHub	β	0.701±0.016	0.683±0.014	+0.017 (2/3)
GitHub	Class TF–IDF	0.727±0.022	0.710±0.020	+0.017 (1/3)
AG News	β	0.586±0.026	0.574±0.019	+0.012 (2/3)
AG News	Class TF–IDF	0.612±0.014	0.584±0.009	+0.028 (3/3)
Civil corpus	β	0.633±0.014	0.623±0.014	+0.010 (2/3)
Civil corpus	Class TF–IDF	0.636±0.014	0.606±0.014	+0.029 (2/3)

background field is missing. Multi-seed read-out differences are largest and most consistent on the civil corpus and are supported for the matched class TF–IDF read-out on GitHub. AG News marks the limit of this effect: the mean class TF–IDF difference is −0.009, and its confidence interval includes zero. Field cooperation therefore does not hold universally: its benefits are confined to particular corpora and particular read-outs.

The concatenated-field control narrows the average coherence gap to +0.010–+0.029 with all six cells positive. This is itself informative: relative to the classical and neural baselines, a single encoder with the same decoder and budget already obtains most of the mean-coherence gain, and the two-stream structure adds +0.010–+0.029 on top; a practitioner who only needs topic words can therefore approach FC-NTM with a single encoder. The case for the two-stream configuration is functional rather than a large average gain — separate field posteriors, a trained missing-field path and the consistency diagnostics that the read-out protocol relies on exist only in the complete configuration. Relative degradation, absolute NLL and topic agreement capture different aspects of missing-field behaviour, while redundancy and field-length statistics describe corpus structure.

The routing experiment uses automatically generated OpenAlex labels for a fixed 15-topic subset covering 42.9% of the test records. It is useful for screening; deployment will require validation with independent, expert-labelled data.

Scope is the main limitation: the evidence covers three English title/body-style corpora, with ten seeds for FC-NTM and BTM and three for the remaining baselines, and FC-NTM hyper-parameters were selected on development data. Two design decisions limit the ablation evidence: the component ablation attenuates rather than eliminates cross-field information flow, because the fused reconstruction term continues to rebuild both fields; and the gating comparison evaluates the gate together with the fusion-reconstruction term, since the gate receives gradients only through that term. Beyond these, several aspects remain untested: other languages, other field conventions and automatically detected field boundaries, as well as validation on larger, independently labelled collections. Within that scope, the released model, protocol and per-seed results give a concrete starting point for missing-field topic modelling on engineering collections.

7 Conclusions

This paper presented FC-NTM, a field-cooperative neural topic model for dual-field short texts: two conditional variational streams share one linear topic decoder, cross-field reconstruction and a consistency regulariser encode the field relation into a shared topic space, and field-level word masking and whole-field dropout handle partial and complete field absence. A single trained model supports a decoder β read-out and a class TF–IDF read-out under one evaluation vocabulary, which removes the vocabulary and topic-length confounds of cross-model comparison.

Across civil engineering title–abstract records and two public corpora, these experiments identify the settings in which each read-out produces measurable differences. The largest and most consistent civil-corpus differences are $+0.049$ C_V for class TF–IDF and $+0.061$ for the β read-out (10/10 seeds). Under the matched class TF–IDF read-out, the GitHub difference is $+0.028$ C_V (95% CI $[+0.012, +0.043]$, 9/10). A same-budget concatenated-field encoder provides a close reference, with mean differences of $+0.010$–$+0.029$ and all six cells positive: the two-stream structure adds little average gain on top of a single encoder with the same decoder and budget, and its value lies in field-level posteriors and native missing-field inference rather than in a large average difference. Title-only routing reaches 0.664 accuracy on the evaluated 15-topic subset. The field-relation measurements and occlusion diagnostics separate changes in topic coherence from changes in posterior structure and word-level prediction. The protocol, the trained model and the per-seed results are released together, so that the framework can be applied to new engineering collections and checked against the same reference results.

Data availability

The code, the fixed corpus splits and the per-seed experimental results that support this study are publicly available in an online repository (the repository link is provided on the separate title page for double-anonymized review). Trained model checkpoints and the per-seed detail dumps are released as assets of the same repository, and access to the third-party source corpora remains subject to the terms and licences of the original providers. The supplementary material (auxiliary experiments and controls, data and metric notes, example topics and case studies) is included in the same online repository as the code and the per-seed results, under `paper/applied_intelligence/`.

Declarations

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Competing interests

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

During the preparation of this work the authors used a large-language-model assistant (OpenAI Codex with a DeepSeek application programming interface) in order to edit and restructure passages that the authors had drafted, to check numerical consistency between the text, tables and stored result files, and to draft a schematic figure and plotting script that the authors verified against the implementation. After using this tool, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the published article. The tool was not used to generate research data, to run or select experiments, to produce results, or to draw scientific conclusions, and no figure was generated by a generative image model.

Author contributions

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